

Open Worship Open Ministry Meeting

prc-open-worship-open-ministry-meeting

Worship Structure · Service Form · practice · minority_lineages · brethren distinctive

DISPUTED

score 0.725
confidence medium

Statement under examination

A meeting in which qualified brothers may, as the Spirit leads, contribute audibly (reading, praying, giving thanks, suggesting a hymn, sharing a word) reflects the participatory pattern Paul describes in 1 Corinthians 14:26-33.

In plain language

First Corinthians 14:26-33 describes a Christian gathering in which more than one person contributes out loud. Verse 26 opens, when you come together, then says each one has, and lists a psalm, a teaching, a revelation, a tongue, and an interpretation, picturing different members each bringing something. Verse 31 adds you can all prophesy one by one, so that all may learn and all be encouraged. A key grammatical detail explains where readers divide. The words for the contributions, has in verse 26 and you can in verse 31, are stated as plain facts, in the indicative mood, so Paul is describing what happens when the church assembles. The words that give commands, in the imperative mood, attach not to the open format but to its aim and its order: let all be done for building up in verse 26, let an interpreter be present, let only two or three speak, let them take turns, let the others weigh what is said, and at the end let all be done decently and in order in verse 40. So the text commands edification and order, and describes, rather than commands, the every member format. That is why the basic shape the proposition points to is genuinely present, while whether it is a binding pattern for all worship is left open by the words themselves. The reciprocal language of Colossians 3:16 and Ephesians 5:19, teaching and admonishing one another and speaking to one another in song, supports mutual participation, but those phrases describe the manner of being filled with the Spirit and letting the word dwell, not a regulated meeting order. The proposition also adds that contributors are limited to qualified brothers, which leans on the separate and contested silence clause a few verses later, and the canon elsewhere also speaks of a recognized teaching role for elders, which the vocabulary here does not rank against the every member pattern. Because the words clearly support audible, multi member participation but do not on their own settle the normativity claim or the brothers only restriction packed into the statement, the lexical verdict is disputed rather than a plain yes or no.

Word dictionary

Every Hebrew and Greek word this study leans on, in everyday terms. Shaded rows are the anchor words the verdict rests on.

Strong	Word	Sounds like	Plain meaning	Times in Bible
G0181	ἀκαταστασία	akatastasia	disorder	5
G0240	ἀλλήλων	allēlōn	one another	101
G0243	ἄλλος	allos	another	
G0303	ἅνα	ana	each	
G0602	ἀποκάλυψις	apokalupsis	revelation	
G1100	γλῶσσα	glōssa	tongue	
G1322	διδαχή	didachē	teaching	

G1417	δύο	duo	two	
G1438	ἑαυτοῦ	heautou	themselves	331
G1520	εἷς	heis	one	367
G1538	ἕκαστος	hekastos	each	91
G1577	ἐκκλησία	ekklēsia	assembly	119
G2192	ἔχω	echō	to have/be	765
G2316	θεός	theos	God	
G3619	οἰκοδομή	oikodomē	building	18
G3956	πᾶς	pas	all	1,316
G4395	προφητεύω	prophēteuō	to prophesy	28
G4396	προφήτης	prophētēs	prophet	149
G4601	σιγάω	sigāō	be silent	10
G4905	συνέρχομαι	sunerchomai	to assemble	
G5010	τάξις	taxis	order	10
G5140	τρεῖς	treis	Three	
G5293	ὑποτάσσω	hypotassō	to subject	42
G5568	ψαλμός	psalmos	psalm	7

Plain meanings: STEPbible brief lexicons TBESH (Hebrew) and TBESG (Greek), CC BY 4.0. Counts are occurrences across the 66-book canon.

Verdict rationale

Variant-robust: True · Pan-canonical: False

The participatory shape is plainly attested at the level of description. In 1 Cor 14:26 the distributive subject ἕκαστος (each one, 91 NT occurrences, stable sense) governs ἔχει repeated five times, and that verb is present active INDICATIVE, so Paul states what happens when the gathered church assembles (ὅταν συνέρχησθε), not a command to do it. Likewise 14:31 δύνασθε...προφητεύειν is indicative plus infinitive (you are able to prophesy), with καθ' ἓνα marking one by one turns. The only IMPERATIVES in the unit attach to purpose and order, not to the open format: γινέσθω πρὸς οἰκοδομήν (14:26), διερμηνεύτω, σιγάτω, λαλείτωσαν, διακρινέτωσαν (14:27-30), and κατὰ τάξιν γινέσθω (14:40). The verdict is disputed because the grammar describes the every-member contribution but commands only edification and order, so the text does not by itself fix whether this is a mandated worship form or the regulation of one charismatic assembly. The stem also imports a brothers-only limit drawn from the separate 14:34 clause, which 26-33 does not lexically supply.

Scripture

1Cor.14.23 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G4905 συνέρχομαι, G1577 ἐκκλησία

Force. συνέλθῃ ἡ ἐκκλησία ὅλη ἐπὶ τὸ αὐτό (if the whole church comes together to the same place) fixes the setting for the unit: συνέρχομαι is the assembly gathering verb, the same verb that opens 14:26 as ὅταν συνέρχησθε. This locates the every member contribution of 14:26 specifically in the gathered church meeting and not in general daily life, which strengthens the participatory reading at the descriptive level.

1Cor.14.26 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G1538 ἕκαστος, G2192 ἔχω, G3619 οἰκοδομή

Force. The distributive subject ἕκαστος (each one) governs ἔχει five times, and the morphology marks ἔχει as present active INDICATIVE third person singular, so the verse states what occurs when they assemble (ψαλμόν, διδαχὴν, ἀποκάλυψιν, γλώσσαν, ἑρμηνεῖαν) rather than commanding it. The single imperative is γινέσθω (let it be done), and it governs not the open format but the purpose πάντα πρὸς οἰκοδομήν (all things for building up). So the grammar describes the contributions and commands only their edifying aim. This is the central verse for the participatory shape and also the central reason the format itself is not lexically mandated here.

1Cor.14.27 · complicates · genre: epistle

Key terms. G1417 δύο, G5140 τρεῖς

Force. The numerical caps κατὰ δύο ἢ τὸ πλεῖστον τρεῖς (by two or at most three) and ἀνὰ μέρος (in turn, one at a time), together with the imperative διερμηνεύτω requiring an interpreter, show the openness is bounded and conditioned. The imperative mood here regulates who may voice a contribution and how, which complicates a reading of the meeting as unrestricted free participation.

1Cor.14.29 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G4396 προφήτης, G0243 ἄλλος

Force. προφῆται δὲ δύο ἢ τρεῖς λαλείτωσαν (let two or three prophets speak) again caps the speakers by an imperative, while οἱ ἄλλοι διακρινέτωσαν (let the others weigh) is a third person plural imperative assigning the rest of the gathered an active discerning role. The plural imperatives distribute speaking and discernment across the assembly, supporting a participatory shape that is nonetheless under command and order.

1Cor.14.31 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G3956 πᾶς, G4395 προφητεύω

Force. δύνασθε γὰρ καθ' ἓνα πάντες προφητεύειν (for you can all prophesy one by one) is the broadest warrant for participation, but δύνασθε is present indicative (you are able) plus the infinitive προφητεύειν, a statement of capacity rather than a command to adopt a format. The distributive καθ' ἓνα (one by one) marks sequential turns and the purpose ἵνα πάντες μανθάνωσιν καὶ πάντες παρακαλῶνται (that all may learn and all be encouraged) ties the capacity to mutual edification. πάντες occurs three times, generalizing the ability to the gathered believers.

1Cor.14.32 · complicates · genre: epistle

Key terms. G5293 ὑποτάσσω, G4396 προφήτης

Force. πνεύματα προφητῶν προφήταις ὑποτάσσεται (the spirits of prophets are subject to prophets), with ὑποτάσσεται a present passive indicative, places the contributions under the speaker's controllable self governance. This undercuts a model of irresistible Spirit prompting that overrides order, and it conditions how the spontaneity in the stem (as the Spirit leads) must operate.

1Cor.14.33 · neutral · genre: epistle

Key terms. G0181 ἀκαταστασία, G2316 θεός

Force. οὐ γὰρ ἐστὶν ἀκαταστασίας ὁ θεὸς ἀλλὰ εἰρήνης (for God is not of disorder but of peace) supplies the theological rationale governing the whole unit. The contrast ἀκαταστασία (disorder, 5 NT occurrences) versus εἰρήνη frames participation as something to be ordered for peace, which both supports a structured open meeting and warns against unregulated contribution.

1Cor.14.40 · neutral · genre: epistle

Key terms. G5010 τάξις, G3956 πᾶς

Force. πάντα δὲ εὐσχημόνως καὶ κατὰ τάξιν γινέσθω (let all be done decently and in order) closes the chapter with the same imperative γινέσθω that governs the purpose in 14:26, now governing τάξις (order). This is the prescriptive counterweight to the descriptive openness: the words that command are about order and seemliness, not about an open format, so the lexical data favor regulated participation rather than either pure spontaneity or a fixed liturgy.

Col.3.16 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G1438 ἑαυτοῦ, G5568 ψαλμός

Force. The present participles διδάσκοντες καὶ νοουθετοῦντες ἑαυτούς (teaching and admonishing one another) in ψαλμοῖς, ὕμνοις, ᾠδαῖς πνευματικαῖς show mutual member to member activity in song and word, but they hang on the imperative ἐνοικεῖτω (let the word of Christ dwell), describing the manner of that indwelling rather than a regulated assembly order. The reflexive ἑαυτούς functions reciprocally and broadens the participatory pattern beyond a single instructor.

Eph.5.19 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G1438 ἑαυτοῦ, G0240 ἀλλήλων

Force. λαλοῦντες ἑαυτοῖς ψαλμοῖς καὶ ὕμνοις καὶ ᾠδαῖς πνευματικαῖς (speaking to one another in psalms and hymns and spiritual songs) uses a reciprocal dative for mutual address, paralleling Col 3:16, and the related ὑποτασσόμενοι ἀλλήλοις (submitting to one another) in 5:21 uses ἀλλήλων. These are present participles dependent on the imperative πληροῦσθε (be filled, 5:18), so they describe the manner of Spirit filling and general thanksgiving rather than a regulated worship order, which both supports mutual participation and limits how far it prescribes a meeting form.

Cross references invoked

From	To	Source	Votes
1Cor.14.26	Eph.5.19	openbible	25
1Cor.14.26	Rom.14.19	openbible	15
1Cor.14.26	1Cor.14.40	openbible	6
1Cor.14.40	Titus.1.5	openbible	16
1Cor.14.40	1Cor.14.26	openbible	13
1Cor.14.31	1Thess.5.11	openbible	3
1Cor.14.32	1Cor.14.29	tsk	1
Col.3.16	Col.4.6	tsk	1

Complicating texts

1Cor.14.34 · addressed

The following clause αἱ γυναῖκες ἐν ταῖς ἐκκλησίαις σιγάτωσαν (let the women keep silent in the churches) restricts who may speak audibly in the same assembly, which is why the proposition limits contributors to brothers. The verb σιγάτωσαν is imperative, but this clause sits outside the cited 26-33 bundle and its scope is itself contested in the wider chapter. It can be read to support the brothers only specification, but it does not lexically establish the proposition's larger claim that open Spirit led participation is a normative worship pattern. It complicates rather than confirms and is one ground of the disputed verdict.

1Cor.14.40 · addressed

πάντα δὲ εὐσχημόνως καὶ κατὰ τάξιν γινέσθω (let all be done decently and in order) closes the chapter by subordinating the openness to decorum and order through the imperative γινέσθω over τάξις. This is addressed in the scripture list as a for and neutral counterweight: the proposition's phrase as the Spirit leads must be read alongside commanded order, so the lexical data favor regulated participation, which the proposition captures only in part.

1Tim.5.17 · unaddressed

The recognized teaching office, οἱ καλῶς προεστῶτες πρεσβύτεροι... οἱ κοπιῶντες ἐν λόγῳ καὶ διδασκαλίᾳ (elders who rule well, who labor in word and teaching), and the order language of Titus 1:5 (cross referenced from 14:40) attest a designated, laboring teaching role that coexists with the every member contribution of 1 Cor 14. This is left unresolved because the vocabulary does not rank the two: the canon supplies both an every member participation pattern and a recognized eldership teaching pattern, and the words do not themselves specify how a meeting should weight or combine them, which is a core reason the normativity question is underdetermined.

Concordance traversed

G1538, G2192, G3956, G4396, G4395, G3619, G5010, G5293, G4601, G0181, G1577, G0240, G1438, G5568, G1520, G1417, G5140, G0303, G4905, G1322, G0602, G1100

Variants

Verdict variant-sensitive: False · ECM status: ecm-shadow

1 Corinthians is outside the open-cbgm 3 John published sample, so CBGM data were not consulted directly and no variant units were available in the bundle. The apparatus markers visible in 14:26-30 (transposition of ἀποκάλυψιν and γλώσσαν, the διερμηνευτής reading in 14:28) touch word order and a single lexical choice but not the indicative force of ἕκαστος ἔχει or δύνασθε...προφητεῦειν, nor the imperatives γινέσθω, σιγάτω, λαλεῖτωσαν. The descriptive versus prescriptive grammar that drives the verdict holds across the readings in view, so the verdict is variant robust.

Hermeneutics

Primary method. grammatico-historical

Frameworks in play. descriptive_vs_prescriptive, continuationism, cessationism

analogia scripturae invoked

descriptive_reading: disputed · Because ἔχει (14:26) and δύνασθε (14:31) are indicative and the only imperatives govern edification and order, this lens reads 26-33 as Paul describing and then regulating a specific Corinthian assembly. The participation is real but the open meeting form is not commanded as a universal pattern, so the proposition's normativity claim is underdetermined and the verdict is disputed.

prescriptive_reading: affirms · This lens takes the present indicatives ἔχει and δύνασθε as describing a settled apostolic norm for the gathered church (located by συνέρχομαι in 14:23, 14:26), reinforced by the reciprocal ἑαυτοὺς and ἀλλήλων of Col 3:16 and Eph 5:19. On this reading the every member, one by one (καθ' ἓνα) contribution is the pattern Paul expects whenever the church assembles, so a meeting open to qualified contributors reflects it directly.

continuationism: affirms · If the prophetic and revelatory gifts described in 14:26-31 continue, the participatory open meeting reads as a directly reproducible pattern, since ἕκαστος ἔχει and καθ' ἓνα πάντες describe an ongoing assembly practice that the church should still expect.

cessationism: disputed · If the revelatory gifts (ἀποκάλυψις, γλώσσα, προφητεία) have ceased, then the chapter regulates a now historical situation, and only the general principle of ordered mutual edification (πρὸς οἰκοδομήν, κατὰ τάξιν) transfers. The specific open ministry form is then underdetermined by the text and left to wisdom rather than command.

The verdict turns on a mood contrast in the Greek: the every member contribution is stated in the indicative (ἔχει, δύνασθε) while the imperatives command edification and order (γινέσθω, διερμηνεύτω, σιγάτω, λαλείτωσαν, διακρινέτωσαν, κατὰ τάξιν γινέσθω). Analogia scripturae is engaged by reading 14:26-33 with the gathering verb in 14:23, the silence and order clauses of 14:27-28, 14:34, 14:40, and the recognized teaching office of 1 Tim 5:17 and Titus 1:5.

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: yes

Neutralized form. Does the lexical data of 1 Corinthians 14:26-33 describe a gathering in which multiple members contribute audibly (reading, prayer, thanksgiving, song, a word), and on what grammatical terms (described practice or commanded form), and who is in view.

The phrase reflects the participatory pattern Paul describes presupposes both that 14:26-33 sets a pattern and that an open ministry meeting matches it, which front loads part of the verdict. The qualifier qualified brothers imports a gender restriction drawn from 14:34 rather than from 26-33. The verdict was derived on the original stem, but the neutralized form isolates the bare lexical questions of who contributes, under what grammatical force, and under what constraint. No VERDICT-CHANGED: the prior disputed verdict is confirmed by the indicative versus imperative mood evidence gathered in this pass.

Citations

Type	Source	License	Redist.	Ref
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	1Cor.14.26
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	1Cor.14.31
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	1Cor.14.40
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	1Cor.14.23
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G1538
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G5293
cross_ref	OpenBible-cross-refs	CC-BY	yes	1Cor.14.26
cross_ref	OpenBible-cross-refs	CC-BY	yes	1Cor.14.40
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	1Cor.14.32

License audit

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Flags

ecm-shadow · lexically-disputed · cross-tradition-divergent · complicating-unresolved